Illustration by RAJ VERMA

rapid prototyping and real-time market sensing. This is precisely where my work on the Three Box Solution becomes more relevant—Box 1: manage the present, Box 2: selectively forget the past, Box 3: create the future. AI could magnify the tensions among these three, compelling leaders to balance them wisely.

In my research and advisory work with global companies, one message consistently emerges: innovation is not a department but an enterprise capability. Classroom learning must be paired with real-world experimentation where students learn from building prototypes and engaging customers rather than simply reading case studies. Innovation is a contact sport, and institutions must invest in innovation labs, industry co-creation studios, live corporate challenges and market immersion programmes.

“Classroom learning must transcend case studies. Institutions should invest in innovation labs, market immersion programmes and live corporate challenge”

India's unique position in a field that I'm well-versed in—reverse innovation i.e. solutions created in emerging markets and later adopted in advanced economies—provides another powerful strategic lens for management education. Resource constraints sharpen creativity, force simplification and yield scalable, inclusive solutions. Management education must focus on underserved markets and design for extreme affordability. India's challenges in healthcare, education, urban mobility, water and energy are, in fact, opportunities to shape the next generation of global innovations.

My recent work on fusion strategy further underscores how AI enables a seamless blending of human wisdom and machine intelligence to create superior value. India, with strong manufacturing bases in two-wheelers, automobiles and tractors, can demonstrate how to build tomorrow's companies that integrate digital and physical systems. Future leaders must treat data as the backbone of strategic thinking by evaluating algorithmic trade-offs and understanding digital ecosystems.

AI is transforming the world of business and the discipline of management, yet the need for human ingenuity, imagination and judgment has never been greater. To aspiring management students: this is your moment. You stand at the intersection of India's rise, AI's acceleration and a global demand for innovation-driven leadership. If you cultivate creativity, resilience and ethical judgment, you will not merely participate in the future—you will shape it. Business schools must evolve boldly, and students must learn courageously; together, we can build leaders who manage the present, selectively forget the past and create the future. ■

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